

New Grad Job Search Tracker

Negotiate like a professional

Educational use only.

This product contains educational information and templates. Nothing here is professional, legal, tax, or investment advice. Consult qualified professionals for your specific situation.

01. Total Compensation: Beyond Base Salary

An offer is never just base salary. It's base + signing bonus + annual bonus % + equity value + benefits value. A \$100K base with \$20K signing bonus, 15% annual bonus, and \$10K equity is different from \$100K base alone. Learn to add these up. Cost-of-living adjustment matters: \$150K in San Francisco (COL ~220) has less purchasing power than \$100K in Austin (COL ~120).

02. Offer Comparison: Worked Example

Offer A (NYC): \$95K base + \$15K signing + 15% bonus (\$14.25K) + \$12K equity + \$8K benefits = \$144.25K. NYC cost-of-living index: 190. Adjusted: $\$144.25K \times (100 \div 190) = \$75.9K$ purchasing power.

Offer B (Austin): \$85K base + \$5K signing + 10% bonus (\$8.5K) + \$8K equity + \$7K benefits = \$113.5K. Austin COL: 120. Adjusted: $\$113.5K \times (100 \div 120) = \$94.6K$ purchasing power.

Result: Offer B is 24.5% better despite lower base salary. Numbers matter; context matters more.

03. Salary Negotiation Scripts

Rule 1: Never reject an offer outright. Rule 2: Always negotiate—it's professional norm. Rule 3: Stay collaborative; you're solving a puzzle together.

Script 1 - "This is our standard offer": "I'm excited about the role. My research shows comparable positions range \$X-\$Y. My background puts me at the higher end. Can we move on base or signing bonus?"

Script 2 - "Equity budget is locked": "I understand. Since equity's constrained, could we increase base or signing bonus to match the full package?"

Script 3 - "We're already fair": "I believe you are. Negotiating is professional norm, not ingratitude. Based on my research, there's room to move on base."

Script 4 - "Final offer": "I hear you. Before I decide, is there flexibility on [base/bonus/start date/remote]?"

Script 5 - "You should be grateful": "I am, genuinely. Negotiating is how professionals handle offers. It doesn't mean I'm ungrateful—it means I'm professional."

04. Application Tracker

Track every application. You'll send 20-50+ applications. A spreadsheet keeps you organized and reminds you to follow up.

Columns: Date applied | Company | Role | Stage (Applied / Phone screen / Technical / Offer) | Follow-up date | Notes

Follow up after 7 days: "Hi [name], I applied to [role] on [date]. Remained very interested. Let me know if you need anything from me."

05. Research Before Interviews

Salary: Glassdoor, Levels.fyi (tech), Payscale, Indeed. Hiring manager: LinkedIn research. Company: Financials (SEC filings), Crunchbase (startups), news. Prepare to answer: "Why this company?" and "What does success look like in 90 days?"

06. Interview Rounds: What to Prepare

Recruiter screen: 30-sec pitch about yourself, 2-3 past project examples, 2-3 questions for them. Technical: Review fundamentals, explain past work in plain language, ask clarifying questions before solving. Final: 1-2 min why-you're-interested, 1-2 questions about strategy/culture, research the interviewer, prepare follow-up email.

07. Quick Reference: Offer Evaluation Checklist

& Base salary (\$ _____) & Signing bonus (\$ _____) & Annual bonus % (____%) & Equity value (\$ _____ / vesting schedule _____ yrs) & Benefits (health, 401k match _____%, PTO _____ days) & Start date & Remote policy & Negotiated? (Y/N) & Decision made (Y/N) Date to decide: _____

